

The Last of the Canalinos

By Margaret Romer

EIGHTEEN YEARS ALONE on a desert island! A woman Robinson Crusoe without benefit of tropical verdure or a helper like "Friday." A saga of nerve, courage, self-reliance — of pure heroism. This is the true story of Juana Maria.

A chain of islands dots the waters off the Southern California coast from the Mexican border to Point Conception above Santa Barbara. Santa Catalina, the popular island vacation paradise, is the best known of these. The outermost of the chain is San Nicolas, some seventy-five miles off shore — unsheltered, wind-torn, rugged and barren. It is only about a third as large as Santa Catalina.

Early in the 1800's the Channel Islands supported about 20,000 peaceful Indians of a high culture level. They were known as the Canalinos. Even San Nicolas had a thousand or so inhabitants. The sea was rich in fish and seals. Especially numerous were the sea otter, gentle little mammals whose luxuriant fur brought fancy prices in the markets of Europe. Otter hunters had a field day. In their greed, they exterminated the otter and decimated the human population of the Islands. The Indians tried to protect their natural heritage and many an unequal battle was fought — bullets against arrows. Finally only a score of Indians was left on San Nicolas. To protect them from complete annihilation, the Mexican Government sent Charles Hubbard of the little schooner appropriately named, "*Peor es Nada*" meaning "Better than Nothing," to bring the natives to the mainland where they could live in security under the protection of the Missions and also receive the blessings of Christian teaching.

San Nicolas is surrounded by dense beds of kelp making landing hazardous. The hunters who visited the Island usually disembarked on a long low sandspit at the eastern end, that was relatively kelp free. Here Captain Hubbard anchored his little craft and struggled to hold it against the wind while the natives brought their possessions aboard.

Juana Maria was a young Indian mother with an infant of about two years — just the age, as every mother knows, when babies

get into everything and you have to have them on a rope to keep track of them! So Juana Maria's baby toddled off and disappeared just at a critical time. All were aboard but the young mother who was frantically searching for her baby. Meanwhile the wind rose to a gale. The restless waters swirled around the Island from both sides and met in a churning tumult causing the little craft to bob around like a leaf. Captain Hubbard had all he could do to manage the vessel. After what seemed to him a reasonable wait, he pulled up the anchor and, in spite of the pleas of the other Indians, sailed off.

The schooner had barely left shore when Juana Maria came running up the beach carrying the baby. The natives begged the Captain to turn back, but he either could not, or would not. But he assured them he would return for the woman and child the next day.

On shore, Juana Maria was terrified at seeing the boat sail off without her. She ran along the beach screaming, "*Mane-quaua!*—*Mane-quaua!*" Her friends on board looked on helplessly and tried to wave her assurance. The young mother stopped and stared — stunned — and watched the schooner until it faded into the horizon. The first shock over, she settled down to wait for the boat's return. Surely they would come back for her and the baby.

Captain Hubbard landed his human cargo at San Pedro, where the San Nicolonians were met by Franciscan missionaries and taken to San Gabriel Mission. Urgent orders awaited the Captain. The *Peor es Nada* was to sail at once for San Francisco. He turned in his report of the mission just completed, including a notation that a woman and child were still on the Island. The paper was duly filed. The second trip to San Nicolas would have to wait until his return from the north.

As the wobbly little schooner was sailing through the Golden Gate, she was hit by an unusually heavy storm, capsized, drifted out to sea, and eventually went to the bottom. But her crew was saved.

At Mission San Gabriel, Juana Maria's people tried to tell the good priests of the young mother's plight, but there was not an Indian to be found who understood the Island language. No one else knew about Juana Maria and her innocent little trouble-making toddler.

The day following the departure of her people, Juana Maria paced the hard sand of the beach watching for the sail that would bring her rescue. It didn't come. Day followed day . . . week followed week. Hope finally died in her heart and she accepted the fact that she had been deserted — forgotten. The baby died, either

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by illness or accident — nobody knows. The young mother wept, as any mother would. She dug a small deep grave on a hillside and buried the child — the last human companion she was to know for eighteen years. In her loneliness she made pets of young otters, and the dogs that were left behind were her friends.

The lone inhabitant of San Nicolas continued to live as her people had always lived. But now she must do everything for herself — hunt, fish, even make the fish-lines and fish-hooks; and awls and knives from the hard wood of the scrub oaks. She built herself new houses as her people had built them. Whale ribs from the occasional dead whales washed up on the shore, stuck upright in the ground for walls, and thatched with brush. There was a seal rookery nearby where she occasionally killed a seal for a dietary change from fish and shell-fish. She made dresses from their skins and fish-lines from the sinews. The fishhooks she fashioned from shells. There were plenty of utensils left by the other natives, but baskets, bowls and bottles woven from grasses wore out, so she had to weave more of them. She made dresses, too, from the feathered skins of cormorants. One of these is now on exhibit at the Vatican.

The Island rises to a peak of some 900 feet. On the slope of this hill, Juana Maria made her home at a spot that commanded a view of the landing spit and of a large portion of the Island. An excellent spring was close at hand, and a seal rookery as well as the best fishing were directly below. Her domicile consisted of three whalebone houses with a brush wall on the windward side. The torrential rains of winter, the howling winds, the booming of the sea in the caves below — of all these, Juana Maria was not afraid. She had but one terror — the hunters who occasionally visited the Island — for it was men like them who had killed most of her people. From her vantage point she could see them land, and she remained in hiding and watched until they went away.

It was generally accepted that San Nicolas was uninhabited, but hunters frequently reported that they had seen evidences of human habitation there. At first these statements were discredited, but they persisted. Then, too, there was a rumor that a woman and a child had been left on the Island at the time the natives were removed to the mainland. This probably came from the crew of the *Peor es Nada* who were rescued from the wreck at the entrance to San Francisco Bay. But nothing was done about it for seventeen long years.

Then in 1852, George Nidever, a respected old sea captain of Santa Barbara, went over to San Nicolas to hunt for seagulls' eggs. He found the eggs — and more — human footprints. He and his

crew discovered, also, that some of the crude shelters on the Island had been recently visited.

Returning to Santa Barbara, Captain Nidever told of his findings. Father Gonzales Rubio was pastor of the Mission parish and also Vicar-General of the Diocese of Monterey. When the good Father heard the news he became greatly interested and asked the Captain to make a thorough search of the Island.

Captain Nidever and a citizen named C. B. Dittman made another trip to San Nicolas in an effort to find the "lost woman." Beside more fresh footprints, they found in the crotch of a bush, a basket of woven grass containing various artifacts including shell fishhooks and a long rope of sinew, all neatly covered with a piece of sealskin. Nidever deliberately scattered these things on the ground and left the spot. Returning some time later, he found the articles replaced and the basket returned to the crotch as before. Now he was convinced. But the men returned to Santa Barbara without finding the woman.

Wise old Captain Nidever guessed the truth. He reasoned that the woman was probably hiding from them from fear, due to the tragic experience of her tribe. He suggested that they organize a rescue party comprised mostly of Indians. Perhaps then she would come out of hiding.

On the next attempt, in July of 1853, Captain Nidever and Mr. Dittman took along four Indians. They planned to search the Island canyon by canyon. Landing at the sandspit at the east end, they prepared to march the entire nine-mile length, scanning every square foot of ground. One of the men must necessarily come upon her. It was arranged that whoever found her was to place his hat on the muzzle of his gun, raise it high and shout. Then the men would close in around her and "capture" her. They did not know what to expect. Would she resist — perhaps fight and scratch? Would they have to take her by force?

The march began. It was slow and difficult. Up and down steep hillsides, over deep gullies, across tedious sand dunes. At last, Mr. Dittman found her, and gave the signal. She was sitting in the sun outside one of her huts, busily engaged in stripping a piece of sealskin. The other men closed in, and her dogs growled as they approached.

When Juana Maria saw that the strangers were men of her own race, she called off her dogs and came forward happily to greet them. She treated them as guests and offered them food. Though they could not converse, they seemed to understand each other.

Juana Maria was then about fifty years of age, with brown

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hair. She was of medium height, well built — a perfect physique, and in perfect health. Shy and quiet, yet self-assured. She wore a dress of feathered cormorant skins that came almost to her ankles.

The rescue party remained a few weeks longer to hunt and to study both the Island, and the "lost woman's" way of life. When they left, she went with them willingly, no doubt looking forward to being re-united with her people. She took a few of her possessions with her, including some seal skins and a few dresses of feathered cormorant skins, and her treasured shell "jewels" which she kept in "jewel boxes" made of two abalone shells hinged together with tar that had drifted up on the beach.

She was ill at ease on the voyage across the water, but recognized the other Channel Islands as they passed and called them by their Indian names. Once on the mainland, she clapped her hands like a child when she first saw an ox-cart and a man on horseback. Captain Nidever took her to his home where his wife took care of her and did everything possible for her comfort and pleasure. She became the pet of the town. It was as if the people were trying to atone for the wrong done her so long ago.

The good padres of the Mission sent a messenger to tell her people of her rescue, only to learn that the other San Nicolonians had all died of illness. They sent for Indians from all the tribes around in an effort to find someone who could understand her language. None did. They did not even know her name, so Father Francisco Sanchez of the Santa Barbara Mission baptized her Juana Maria.

After living alone so long, Juana Maria had become completely uninhibited — a child of nature. Naive, she conformed to no customs. She would sing whenever she felt like it — which was most of the time, for she was a happy soul. Though her voice was not of the prima donna class, it was at least a spontaneous expression of joy. Seldom walking, she usually went dancing along with a hop-skip-and-jump, or on the run. She loved to go visiting from house to house among the Indians and Mexicans. Everyone loved her.

Captain Nidever acted as her guardian and he provided liberally to keep her well dressed and comfortable. A traveling show offered him a large sum of money to allow them to take her on the road for exhibition. To his credit, he refused the offer.

But the food of civilization did not agree with Juana Maria. She developed stomach trouble. By that time, too, she knew that she would never see her people again. Hopelessness and acute gastritis combined to take their toll. In spite of the best medical care available, the joyous voice was hushed, the dancing steps ceased.

In less than three months after her "rescue," Padre Gonzales Rubio spoke the Last Rites and laid to rest in the cemetery of Mission Santa Barbara, the brave, resourceful child of God, Juana Maria.

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